G Minor

Scale Practice Worksheet · Two flats — B♭, E♭ · 2 to 4 octaves

Note on minor scales

Practice the harmonic and melodic forms, not the natural minor alone.

The natural minor in G uses B♭ and E♭ throughout.

The harmonic minor raises the 7th: F♮ becomes F♯.

The melodic minor raises both the 6th and 7th ascending — E♭ becomes E♮, F♮ becomes F♯ — and reverts to natural minor descending (F♮, E♭ on the way down).

SCALES

01 Harmonic Minor — Parallel & Contrary Motion

Play G harmonic minor up and down in two octaves first, then expand to four. The harmonic minor raises the 7th degree: F♮ becomes F♯.

Once parallel motion is fluid, add contrary motion — hands moving in opposite directions, one ascending while the other descends simultaneously.

TIP
Start slow, prioritize evenness over speed.

02 Melodic Minor — Parallel & Contrary Motion

Ascending: raise both the 6th and 7th degrees — E♮, F♯.

Descending: revert to natural minor — F♮, E♭ on the way back down (**G – F♮ – E♭ – D – C – B♭ – A – G**).

In contrary motion, the ascending hand plays the melodic form (with E♮ and F♯) while the descending hand plays the natural form (with E♭ and F♮). Two different patterns happen at once — then reverse which hand plays which on the return.

03 Scale in Tenths

Play the scale in tenths between the hands. The right hand plays a third above the left hand's note, in the octave above — the interval is a tenth, which is a third plus an octave. Both hands move together up the scale, then add contrary motion on a second pass.

> **TIP**
> The point of this exercise is listening, not just playing. Both hands have to be perfectly aligned. Engage the ear; let the hands follow what the ear demands.

04 Hanon Variation

A short turning figure applied to the G minor scale as a warm-up. Play a small four-note turn — up and back — on each scale degree in turn, working the pattern through the scale up and down. Practice each hand separately. Useful for the left hand position in particular; the right hand should match the same feel.

> **TIP**
> Hanon No. 1 and No. 23 can be substituted in for additional finger work in this position. They are particularly good for breaking the boredom of straight scale practice while still training the same muscles.

05 D7 Chord

The dominant chord is built on the fifth degree of the scale. In G minor, that is D, and the dominant seventh chord is **D – F♯ – A – C** — a major triad with an added minor seventh.

Play the chord as solid four-note chords (triad plus the seventh) across the keyboard, with inversions: root, 1st, 2nd, 3rd. To get familiar with the shape, first add an octave on top: **D – F♯ – A – C – D** (five notes, triad plus seventh plus octave).

> TIP
> If the five-note version is too big a stretch, play only the four-note **D – F♯ – A – C**. Keep the wrists flexible and the hands free. Avoid lifting the shoulders or locking the elbows close to the body — small shoulder movement helps confirm the arms are loose.

06 D7 Broken Arpeggios

Play **D – F♯ – A – C** as a broken arpeggio across the keyboard. The chord tones are split into pairs that jump between intervals rather than climbing straight through them.

Pattern (grouped in fours, each group spans across octaves):

D – A – F♯ – C

A – D – F♯ – C

A – D – C – F♯

A – D – C – F♯

D – A

— and so on across the keyboard.

Work through all four inversions: root, 1st, 2nd, 3rd. The intervals between the chord tones are wide, and the splits force the hand to reach.

> TIP
> Stay in the middle of each key. Avoid sliding inside and outside the keys — every unnecessary movement reduces speed. Avoid relying on finger stretching alone; include forearm rotation and flexible wrists. As the tempo increases, the movements become small but they should still be present.

07 F#°7 Chord and Arpeggios

The diminished chord is built on the seventh degree of the harmonic minor — the altered seventh, F♯, not F♮. The full diminished seventh chord is **F♯ – A – C – E ♭** (stacked minor thirds, four notes). Play as solid chords and as broken arpeggios across the keyboard.

08 F#°7 Hand-Crossing — Debussy / Ravel Texture

Crossing the left hand over the right is a technique used constantly in Debussy and Ravel. Applied to the diminished arpeggio, it creates a continuous one-hand-sounding line that neither hand could produce on its own. The goal is to make the sound feel as if a single hand is playing — no unevenness between the hands at the crossing point.

The left hand crosses over to the upper register and back quickly. Avoid lifting the hands too high during the crossing — height costs time. Practice each inversion separately:

a — Root position

F♯ – A – C – E ♭ . Practice the crossing motion alone first, focusing on the connection at the moment the hands swap.

b — First inversion

A – C – E ♭ – F♯. The right hand adds the top note with the 3rd finger.

c — Second inversion

C – E ♭ – F♯ – A.

d — Third inversion

E ♭ – F♯ – A – C.

e — Reverse the crossing direction

Swap which hand goes on top. Whatever hand was crossing over now stays beneath, and vice versa. Practice both directions on every inversion.

RAVEL VARIATION

09 Diminished + F♮ — Ravel Sonority

A variation of the diminished chord drawn from Ravel's harmonic language. Take the F♯°7 chord (**F♯ – A – C – E♭**) and add F♮. The resulting sonority — **F♮ – F♯ – A – C – E♭** — is the dreamy, mysterious chord that appears throughout Ravel's writing.

Play this five-note chord using the over-hand technique established in Exercise 08. The added F♮ creates an extra layer of unevenness in the arpeggio that has to be worked through deliberately. The aim is a harp-like sound, which depends entirely on a smooth transition between the hands.

> **TIP**
> A small amount of pedal can support the harp sound here once the transition is clean — but the pedal is a finishing layer, not a substitute for the work.

VARIATIONS

Contrary Motion

Any scale or arpeggio exercise can be played in contrary motion — one hand ascending while the other descends simultaneously. Harder than parallel motion and excellent brain training.

Accent & Rhythmic Variations

Apply to any scale or arpeggio exercise for fluidity and evenness:

a Accent every note — extra weight on each individual note.

b Accent every second note — grouped, rolling feel.

c Triplet groupings — organize the scale in groups of three.

d Groups of four — organize the scale in groups of four.

e Prolong one note per group — hold the 2nd or 3rd note slightly longer to build control.

f Groups of seven — the scale normally falls in groups of eight, so grouping in sevens shifts the accent and exposes unevenness.

Staccato

Any scale exercise can be played staccato — lift from each key rather than connecting the notes. Treat it as a separate pass, not a replacement for legato practice.

GENERAL PRACTICE PRINCIPLES

- Scales are not just finger work — listening for hand alignment is the actual goal, especially in tenths and at the moment of crossing in hand-crossed passages
- Pedal is a finishing layer applied after the technique is clean, not a tool to cover unfinished playing
- Forearm rotation and flexible wrists do work that finger stretching alone cannot — include them even at high tempo, where the movements become small but stay present
- Do not practice scales with the pedal down — the pedal masks unevenness and hides the exact spots that need more work; most practice should be dry so the problems are audible
- Every unnecessary movement at the keyboard reduces speed — keep motion small, central to each key, and free of lifting or sliding
- Invent variations on the basic patterns to keep practice alive; scales practiced with structured creativity train better than scales practiced from boredom